ended up confined within approximately the same boundaries as it has today.

Even so, the country was far from stable. Frictions within the royal family in the 1840s led to a massacre at Kot, where the military commander Jung Bahadur Rana killed about 40 men from the palace court —and subsequently introduced the hereditary premiership of the Rana family. The kings became mere figureheads.

In the following decade, China was weakened by a number of internal conflicts, the most serious of which was the Taiping rebellion in 1851–64. Kathmandu's already strained relations with Lhasa led to armed conflict with the Tibetans, and indirectly with the Chinese. In 1856, an agreement was negotiated with the Chinese resident in Lhasa under which Nepalese merchants were granted duty-free trade privileges in Tibet, while the Tibetans were forced to pay an annual tribute of 10,000 Nepalese Rupees to Kathmandu. A Nepalese resident was also allowed to stay in Lhasa. Nepal gave up its territorial claims in the north and agreed that it, as well as Tibet, would remain a tributary state subject to the emperor in Beijing, an agreement that did not please the Tibetans but which they grudgingly had to accept. But as China disintegrated further, Nepal, as well as Tibet, were able to shake off this subordination. And it was Britain rather than China that came to exert the most outside influence in Nepal and, to a lesser extent, on Tibet.[47]

As relations with the British improved—Nepalese troops had supported the British during the 1857–8 uprising, which the colonial power preferred to call 'the Sepoy rebellion'—the British came to accept the rule of the Ranas and the Nepalese were rewarded for their loyalty by being returned some territories in the southern plains. Nepal had built up a formidable military force centred on the Gorkha army of the first kings of the Shah Dynasty. Military techniques and technology were copied from British models, including an armaments industry. The British also discovered the fighting prowess of the Nepalese army and, after the British crown took over India from the East India Company after the rebellion, Nepal became an important source of recruits for the British military.

Although British influence remained strong, Nepal was able to preserve its national independence in a way Sikkim, and even Bhutan, could not. The country was bigger and more populous, and the Ranas were able to use their total control over domestic affairs to isolate Nepal from events in